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Realism & Artifacts

AI image generators fail in predictable ways. Knowing the patterns lets you spot problems quickly — and describe them precisely enough to support a rating.

Example — editing for lighting & shadow realism

In an **image-editing task**, the model gets an original photo plus a prompt asking for changes, and you compare the edited outputs — here, on how believably each handles light and shadow.

Prompt
Can you make this bicycle look like a vintage cream city bike with a small wicker front basket?
Soften the lighting a little and make it feel like an early morning street scene.

Original



Edit A



Edit B — fewer artifacts



Edit B wins. Low directional morning light casts a dappled shadow across the wall, and the bike sits on a proper contact shadow — a believable early-morning street, which is what the prompt asked for.

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Edit A has two tells: a pedal is missing, and the ground shadow doesn't line up with any light source (the wall is lit flat, no texture). The lighting was softened by *flattening* it — an "AI-flat" studio shot, not a street scene.

Anatomy, texture & realism

These are the areas where generation artifacts concentrate most.

Faces

- Proportions: eye spacing, nose-to-mouth distance, jawline shape
- Eyes: are pupils the same size? Are catchlights (reflections) consistent between eyes?
- Skin: overly smooth or waxy skin is a common generation tell — real skin has pores, variation, and subtle texture

Hands Hands are the most common failure point. Check: finger count, finger length relative to palm, visible knuckles, natural overlap between fingers. Fused or missing fingers are immediate flags.



A typical AI hand failure — wrong finger count, unnatural fusing, and implausible joint structure. This is what to scan for before rating anatomy.

Bodies and limbs

- Limb length: arms and legs should be proportional to torso
- Joints: elbows and knees should bend at anatomically plausible points
- Clothing: fabric should drape, fold, and crease with the body underneath it

Surfaces and materials Real materials have characteristic texture: skin has pores, fabric has weave, hair has individual strands, metal reflects. Over-smooth surfaces, tiled patterns, and loss of fine detail are all artifact signals.

You're rating an AI-generated portrait. Which observation is the strongest anatomy-based artifact flag?

The subject is smiling with their mouth slightly open

The right hand shows six fingers, and the thumb appears fused to the index finger

The background is slightly out of focus

The subject's shirt is a solid color

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Check answer

AI artifact patterns

Artifacts cluster into four categories:

- Anatomy failures
- Texture problems
- Text rendering
- Object & scene inconsistencies

Text rendering and structural anatomy are the two artifact types that show up most in complex prompts. The image below was generated with a Chinese-language speech bubble — the characters are distorted and unreadable, a failure mode that's especially common with non-Latin scripts:



Prompt requested a Chinese speech bubble saying "Look! Panda!" — the model produced garbled pseudo-characters instead of legible text.

Structural failures happen when a model can't maintain anatomical logic across a complex body. This centaur was generated by Stable Diffusion — the human-to-horse transition is incoherent, with mismatched proportions and impossible joint geometry:

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Stable Diffusion centaur — the model has no real understanding of how two body types should connect, so the anatomy collapses at the join.

A prompt asks for a storefront sign that reads "Fresh Bread." The generated image shows a sign with letter-like shapes that don't spell anything readable. Which artifact category is this?

Anatomy failure

Object & scene inconsistency

Text rendering

Texture problem

Check answer

Describing what you see

Ratings are only useful if the justification supports them. Grounded descriptions reference what is actually in the image — not how it makes you feel.

Weak (subjective)	Strong (observable)
"This looks off"	"The shadow on the left wall falls at a different angle than the shadow under the chair"
"The hands look weird"	"The right hand has six fingers; the thumb and index finger appear fused"
"Image A is better quality"	"Image A has sharper hair detail and consistent shadow direction; Image B's background is smeared and the subject's left arm is unnaturally elongated"
"B feels more realistic"	"B has more consistent skin texture and natural fabric draping; A has waxy skin and a visible seam at the subject's collar"

When writing a justification: name the element, describe what you observe, and connect it to the axis you're rating.

Which justification best supports a lower rating on realism?

Image A just feels off compared to Image B

Image A's cast shadow falls to the left of the subject while the window light comes from the left, and the subject's left hand has fused fingers

Image A is clearly AI-generated

Image A doesn't look as good as Image B

Check answer

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